

The Penny-Pincher

You want to buy a PC. Naturally, you want to spend as little as possible. Agent 001 tells you how

Month after month I receive mails asking about optimal PC configurations. That “optimal” might as well read “cheapest.” The performance crown might be high on Intel’s and AMD’s wish-lists, but the ground reality is quite different. Cheap sells.

A few years ago, Rs 25,000 used to be the price for “a very affordable PC”; today, that figure is something like Rs 10,000. I often come across ads offering PCs at around Rs 10K. What kind of components do these PCs come with?

It’s not possible for me to go about checking the hardware components that go into each and every brand’s sub-10K offerings—besides, there’s often fine print involved in those cases—so I decided to do my own investigations and assemble the cheapest PC remembering not to compromise too much on the quality of components. Everyone wants to strike a deal and get the cheapest possible rates; however, it shouldn’t come at the expense of performance. In other words, “the cheapest PC” should not be defined by cost alone, because at the end of the day it’s a utility device—something you’ll be spending time with every day. Assigning some weightage to performance is therefore a must.

“Performance” by itself is a vague term and has different connotations for different people. So instead of giving you a magic configuration—a one-stop solution for everything—I am offering two different solutions, addressing two different performance levels.

Configuration 1

You want: A PC for basic Internet usage, word processing, possibly for accounting, inventory management, or perhaps for programming...

My suggestion: Such a PC will be based on the least expensive hardware available. Prices will vary, but not by much. If you want an Intel solution, opt for a Celeron 2.1 GHz with an ASRock 845 chipset-based motherboard; this combo will set you back by another Rs 1,000.

What to expect: Since this is based on a VIA chipset, graphics will be a sore point, and most games won’t run—but routine apps won’t suffer. This machine will be a great beginner’s PC; for example, if you want to introduce your kids to the world of computers without hurting your wallet, this is what the doctor ordered.

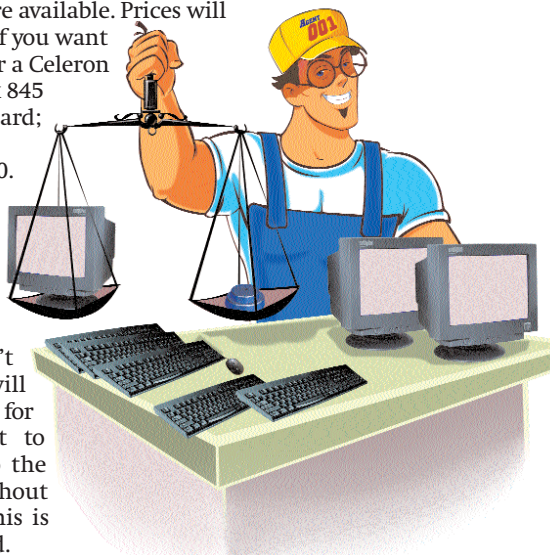


Illustration Pradip Ingale

Configuration 1: A basic computer for general use		
Component	Brand / Specifications	Cost (Rs)
Processor + Motherboard	AMD Sempron 2500+ An MSI or Gigabyte board based on a VIA chipset	4,500 (for the combo)
RAM	Transcend 256 MB DDR 400	1,100
Hard Drive	Seagate / Samsung / Hitachi / WD 80 GB (give or take Rs 150 here)	2,350
Monitor	Samsung / LG 15-inch CRT	3,950
Optical Drive	LG combo drive	1,450
Keyboard and Mouse	Logitech (ball mouse)	500
Cabinet	A cabinet from Frontech, Kobian, Perx, or other such brands, with a 350-watt power supply	1,000
Speakers	Stereo desktop speakers from any Taiwanese / Chinese brand	300
Total		15,500

Configuration 2

You want: A reasonably powerful, upgradeable, multimedia PC that’s not too hard on the pocket.

My Suggestion: This configuration is based around an Intel dual-core and a 945 chipset motherboard. The 945 chipset supports Vista, thus offering headroom for upgrades. It has onboard graphics, but can be upgraded for better performance using the PCIe slot. The PC still hovers round the 25K sweet spot.

What to expect: Since it’s based on reasonably good onboard hardware, the PC will allow you to play recent games at low resolutions and settings. With 512 MB of memory, most multimedia applications won’t bog the system down. The 17-inch monitor ensures a good Internet experience.

You can, of course, tinker around with these configurations, and if you’re wondering about a particular point, just drop in a mail! ■

Configuration 2: A multimedia computer		
Component	Brand / Specifications	Cost (Rs)
Processor	Intel Pentium D 805	5,750
Motherboard	Intel Original 945GNTL	6,200
RAM	Transcend 512 MB DDR2 667 MHz	2,300
Hard Drive	Seagate / Samsung / Hitachi / WD 80 GB (give or take Rs 150 here)	2,350
Monitor	Samsung / LG 17-inch CRT	5,500
Optical Drive	LG combo drive	1,450
Keyboard and Mouse	Logitech (optical mouse)	800
Cabinet	Any decent cabinet with a 400-watt power supply	1,500
Speakers	Creative stereo desktop speakers	500
Total		26,350

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